PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

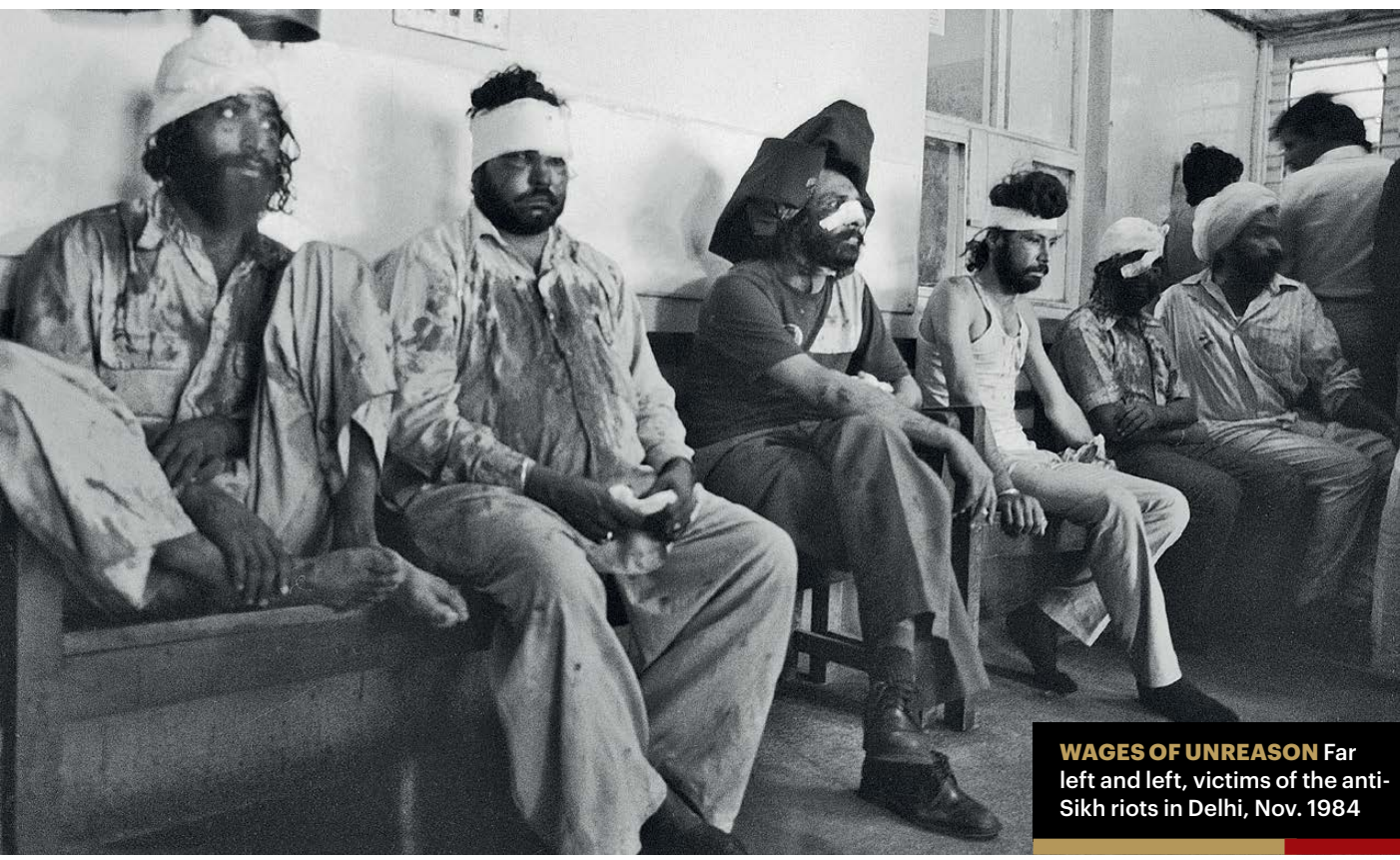


| PUNJAB |

TORTURED YEARS

Unbridled terrorism by Khalistani separatists took Punjab to the brink of collapse. It would take years to heal

Punjab entered its darkest decade soon after Operation Bluestar, with Bhindranwale's 'martrydom' drawing thousands of youths to the Khalistan agitation in an atmosphere of religious revivalism. The detonation occurred when Mrs Gandhi was assassinated by two Sikh bodyguards on October 31, 1984. In the next three days, frenzied mobs of Hindus, often led or unleashed by Congress leaders, tore into Sikhs across North India, murdering over 8,000—the worst communal violence since Partition. Delhi, its administration absent, was swept in an orgy of bloodlust. From here, the cycle of violence accelerated. Groups like Babbar Khalsa and Khalistan Commando Group, its men often trained by Pakistan, let loose a wave of terror. Buses and trains were raided and Hindus killed, and crude 'transistor bombs' claimed many lives. It would take years—a further flushing out of terrorists from the Golden Temple in 1986 and 1988, determined action by the army/police and acts like the assassination of Shiromani Akali Dal chief Harchand Singh Longowal—before the bloody cycle of terrorism and state retribution faded away in Punjab. ■



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

WAGES OF UNREASON Far left and left, victims of the anti-Sikh riots in Delhi, Nov. 1984